

The Masterclass Series

Nine advanced modules for the specialist worlds a private concierge must move through with ease.

The eight-week programme makes you fluent in the craft. These masterclasses make you fluent in its specialist domains, the ones where a single wrong word marks you as an outsider and a single right one marks you as a professional. Read the one you need before you need it.

Masterclass I · The Yacht

A yacht is not a floating house. It is a regulated vessel with a legal master, a crew living in the same steel as the guests, and a schedule dictated by weather, berths and fuel. The people who fail here arrive with the habits of a land house and start giving instructions. Your work afloat is to be useful, early, and to know exactly whose decision each thing is.

The captain, and the authority you will never have. The captain is master of the vessel and holds authority in law over the yacht and every person aboard, crew and guests alike, including the owner or charterer. That is not a courtesy of rank. It follows from maritime law and from personal liability for the safety of the ship. A captain can refuse a passage, refuse an anchorage, order a guest ashore and end a charter, and importance on land changes none of it. So you never instruct a captain. You state the objective and ask what is possible. A captain who is asked will move mountains. One who is told will move nothing.

The chief stewardess, your real counterpart. The interior belongs to the chief stewardess, sometimes titled chief steward or interior manager. Cabins, service, laundry, flowers, table settings, dietary execution and the rhythm of the day all sit there. If you are the household side of a trip, this relationship decides whether the week is smooth. Build it before the guests arrive. Send the preference sheet early and complete, then telephone. Ask what they need from you rather than announcing what you require. A good chief stewardess already knows things you do not, about stowage, the water in that anchorage, and which florist actually delivers in August.

The purser, the broker and the central agent. On larger yachts a purser handles accounts, crew administration and the charter money; on smaller yachts the captain or chief stewardess absorbs it. Learn which, because it tells you where an invoice goes. In chartering there are two brokers and they are not on the same side. The retail broker

acts for the client. The central agent holds the exclusive mandate to market that yacht and acts for the owner. Both are professional, both are paid from the same fee, and their duties run in opposite directions. When a central agent says the yacht is perfect for your family, that is a sales position, not advice.

The contract and the allowance. Most Mediterranean and Caribbean charters use a MYBA form or a close variant. It sets delivery and redelivery, the cruising area, the number of guests sleeping aboard and what is included. Alongside the fee sits the Advance Provisioning Allowance. The APA is a working float, commonly around a quarter to a third of the charter fee, paid in advance and held by the captain for fuel, food, drink, berthing and port fees. It is not a fee. It is your money, spent on your behalf, and it is reconciled with receipts before disembarkation. A mid week request to top it up is normal, and fuel is usually the reason. A reconciliation without receipts is not.

The number nobody quotes. The advertised weekly rate is the base fee and nothing else. Above it sit the APA, value added tax where the cruising waters attract it, and the crew gratuity. Tax treatment varies by country and by the structure of the charter, so it is quoted by the broker for that itinerary rather than assumed. Gratuity convention in both seasons commonly falls somewhere between five and fifteen per cent of the charter fee, discretionary, given to the captain for distribution. Quote your principal the all in figure with the assumptions written underneath. Anyone who discovers the real cost after signing remembers who gave them the small number.

The preference sheet is the trip. It gathers names, ages, cabin allocation, allergies, medical notes, dietary rules, forbidden foods, drinks and brands, bed firmness, pillows, scents to avoid, sleeping hours, celebrations falling in the week, water sports confidence and whether the children can swim. Completed properly, the crew pre position the right wine, the right dietary stock, the right wetsuit and the right high chair. Completed vaguely, they guess, and the guess will be competent and wrong. Send it a fortnight ahead where you can. Anything rare, a vintage, a specific gluten free bread, a formula milk, a medication, needs longer, because it must be found ashore in a named port and delivered to a moving boat.

Provisioning, tenders and toys. Provisioning is logistics, not shopping. A yacht at anchor is supplied by tender from a harbour that may be commercial, restricted, or closed that day. Perishables, cold chain and specialist diets go on the earliest list, and wine and spirits are best loaded before the charter begins because duty and availability change with the waters. Tenders and toys are governed by sea state and by law rather than enthusiasm. Jet skis are licensed and restricted in many jurisdictions and often banned after dark. Large inflatables need deck crew and a calm anchorage. Diving requires certification, and for an uncertified guest the honest answer is an instructor led dive ashore.

Life aboard, and the lines you do not cross. Crew areas are crew areas. You do not enter the galley, the crew mess or the bridge uninvited, and neither do guests. Nothing goes down a marine head that has not been eaten first, because a blockage removes a crew member from service for hours. If you travel as household staff rather than as a guest, you are crew for the week, and you eat, sleep and behave accordingly however senior you are ashore. Take that graciously; the crew decide within an hour which kind of person you are.

Seasons, and why timing decides everything. The Mediterranean season runs broadly from late spring to early autumn, with July and August effectively spoken for. The Caribbean season runs broadly from December to April, with Christmas and New Year the most contested weeks of the year, usually sold on premium terms and a minimum duration. Between the two, yachts cross the Atlantic or sit in yard period and are unavailable at any price. Monaco during the Grand Prix, Cannes during the festival and Saint Barths at New Year are berth questions before they are charter questions. Asked in May about August, you answer honestly and immediately rather than optimistically.

How it fails. It fails when someone tells the captain what will happen. It fails when the preference sheet arrives two days out with the word standard written across it. It fails when the charter fee is quoted as though it were the cost. It fails when nobody asked whether the children can swim. It fails when guests bring an unannounced extra person, because the overnight guest number is a certification limit and not a question of finding a pillow. And it fails quietly when the APA is never reconciled and nobody asks.

Case I. The dinner in the next bay. On the fourth night the principal decides at six that the party of twelve should dine ashore in a port ninety minutes away. The captain says the passage is possible, but the anchorage there is exposed and the forecast is building overnight.

The debrief. The captain has already given you the answer in its polite form. Exposed plus building means the yacht rolls all night, the guests sleep badly, and the tender run back after dinner is wet and possibly unsafe in the dark. You do not relay that as a refusal, and you do not carry a version of it to the principal that sounds like a veto. You offer two workable options: a good table ashore in the present bay tonight, or the same restaurant tomorrow at lunch with a daylight passage and a calm return. Then the sentence that protects everyone, that the captain is content with either. The general rule afloat is that you convert a nautical constraint into a choice before it reaches the family, and you never let the captain be the person who says no.

Case II. The allowance that ran out. On day five the captain asks for a further APA payment. The principal is irritated and asks you whether the crew are spending it on themselves.

The debrief. This is an accounting conversation, not a trust conversation, so you settle it with paper rather than reassurance. Ask for the running statement and receipts to date. The answer is almost always fuel, because the yacht moved further and faster than the itinerary assumed, and fuel dwarfs everything else on the sheet. Show the breakdown, note that the APA is the principal's float and not crew income, and explain that the alternative to topping up is a shorter cruising range for the remaining days. Then remove the cause: agree the rest of the itinerary with the captain, ask for the estimated burn against it, and set a daily reporting line. Money aboard is reconciled continuously, not at the end.

Your checklist, before a charter. Do you know who holds the money aboard. Has the preference sheet gone out complete, and has someone spoken to the chief stewardess by voice. Is the figure you gave your principal the all in one, with tax and gratuity assumptions written down. Are the overnight guest numbers within certification. Does the crew know every allergy, medication and non swimmer before anyone steps aboard. And have you agreed how the APA will be reported to you, on which day, and by whom.

Masterclass II • Private Aviation

Private aviation looks like freedom and is in fact one of the most heavily regulated things a family will ever do. Almost every delay you will have to explain is legal rather than mechanical. Learn the rules that govern crew, customs and airspace and you stop being the person who apologises for the aircraft and become the person who saw it coming.

The four ways a family flies. Full ownership means the family holds the asset and carries crew, hangarage, maintenance and depreciation, usually through a management company. Fractional ownership buys a share of an aircraft type with guaranteed access on defined notice, sold in hours. A jet card is prepaid block hours on a fleet at fixed rates. On demand charter is a single trip booked from an operator, usually through a broker. What is being bought in each case is availability rather than an aircraft. A family flying a few trips a year is usually better served by charter; a family flying constantly is buying certainty of access.

The management company. Owners rarely operate their own aircraft. A management company employs and rosters the crew, holds the operating certificate, arranges maintenance, insurance and hangarage, files flight plans, and often charts the aircraft out when the owner is not using it. That last point matters: an owner's aircraft may be away on a revenue charter, so availability is a scheduling question rather than a right. Know who owns your account there, and know their out of hours number, because the person who answers at two in the morning decides whether a problem is solved that night.

The FBO, and why it is the whole experience. The fixed base operator is the private terminal. It handles arrival, security, immigration where applicable, catering delivery, ground transport onto the apron where permitted, crew facilities and fuelling. Most large airports have several and they are not interchangeable: they differ in position on the field, in how close the car may drive, and in how discreet the arrival is. Name the FBO in writing on every booking, confirm it the day before, and give the driver its address rather than the airport name, because the two are often kilometres apart.

Tail numbers and empty legs. Every aircraft carries a registration, the tail number, and that number is how it is identified in flight plans, handling requests and public tracking. Treat it as sensitive. It is the easiest way for an outsider to follow a family's movements, and it belongs in no group chat, no post and no email to a vendor who does not need it. An empty leg is a repositioning flight with no passengers, offered at a reduced rate. It is genuinely good value and genuinely unreliable, because it moves or disappears when the paying trip that created it changes. It suits a flexible traveller and almost never suits a principal with a fixed appointment.

Lead times, honestly. On demand charter can often be arranged inside a day for a straightforward domestic trip with a readily available aircraft. Anything international, anything requiring overflight or landing permits, anything into a restricted or slot controlled airport, and anything at a peak period needs considerably longer. Permits for some countries take days rather than hours, and major fixtures, fairs and summits saturate aircraft and parking alike. A day is a reasonable working minimum for a simple trip. Anything unusual is started as soon as the idea exists, before it is confirmed.

Catering, which is ordered rather than cooked. Aircraft galleys reheat rather than cook, so menus are built around food that survives a warming oven or is served cold. Catering is ordered through the operator or FBO from specialist providers, typically on a day's notice and more for anything unusual. State allergies in writing in the booking and repeat them to the crew on the day, because the person loading the trolley is not the person who took the order. Anything the family genuinely cares about, a particular bread, a specific tea, a child's usual yoghurt, is easier to send with them than to source at an unfamiliar airport before dawn.

Customs, the general declaration and the paperwork. Private does not mean unexamined. Every international flight requires passenger and crew manifests, and the general declaration, the gendec, is the standard document listing the aircraft, crew and passengers presented to authorities on arrival and departure. Passport details must be exact and supplied in advance; a transposed number can hold an aircraft on the ground. Customs and immigration attend the FBO by arrangement, in some countries only at certain airports and hours. Cash above threshold amounts must be declared and thresholds differ by jurisdiction. Valuables carried in the cabin, jewellery, watches, art,

may attract duty or need documentation on entry, which is a conversation for the family office before departure rather than at the counter.

Pets, luggage and weight. Pets travel in the cabin on private aircraft, but the paperwork is national law and it is unforgiving: microchip, rabies vaccination with the correct waiting period, an animal health certificate issued inside a defined window, and for some destinations tapeworm treatment or an import permit. Rabies free island states are strictest, and the penalty for arriving without the right document falls on the animal, so start weeks ahead. Luggage is limited by volume as much as weight, since holds on light and midsize aircraft are small and oddly shaped, so skis, golf bags and hanging garments are declared at booking. Passengers, bags and fuel compete, and on a long leg the trade is fuel against payload.

Crew duty time, the real limit on your schedule. The constraint that surprises families most is not the aircraft, it is the crew. Flight and duty time limitations cap how long a crew may work, including the time before and after the flight, and mandate minimum rest between duties. Those rules are law and negotiable by nobody. A crew on duty since dawn cannot absorb four extra hours, and if the delay breaks the limit the aircraft does not move until they have rested or a fresh crew is positioned, which can take a day. That is how a two hour delay becomes an overnight. When a principal runs late, your first call asks the crew how much of their window remains.

Slots, parking and de icing. Busy airports allocate slots, permissions to move at a defined time, and missing one means waiting for the next. Parking at peak events is finite, and an aircraft that cannot park will drop its passengers and reposition elsewhere, which changes your ground plan. In winter, de icing is a queue with a limited holdover time, so an aircraft treated and then delayed must be treated again. None of this is failure. It is the system working, and it is why an itinerary carries slack.

How it fails. It fails when the tail number sits in a group chat. It fails when a driver is given the airport rather than the FBO. It fails when a passport detail is entered from memory, when two guests are added on the morning of a full aircraft, or when the dog's health certificate falls a week outside its window. And it fails most often when nobody asked about crew duty, so the aircraft was ready and the people were not.

Case I. The two hour delay that became tomorrow. Departure is at four. At three the principal is still in a meeting and asks to hold the aircraft until seven. The crew reported at midday.

The debrief. Ask the crew, immediately and specifically, what time they must be airborne to complete the flight inside their duty limit. That number is the answer and it is not a preference. Take it to the principal as a hard deadline with the consequence attached: airborne by a stated hour, or the aircraft cannot legally depart tonight and tomorrow morning becomes the plan. Ask the operator in parallel what a fresh crew would take. Never present the limit as the operator being difficult, because it is law.

The rule is that you establish the real deadline before you promise anything, and you hand the family a decision rather than a delay.

Case II. The dog at the door. The family decide the day before an international departure that the dog is coming.

The debrief. Check the paperwork before you check the seat. Confirm the destination's import requirements, that the microchip predates the rabies vaccination, that the waiting period has elapsed, and that the health certificate was issued inside the required window by an authorised veterinarian. If anything is missing, the honest answer is that the animal cannot travel on this flight and the useful answer is a plan: a veterinary appointment today and the dog following later in the week with a trusted handler. Tell the operator regardless, because animals on board affect cleaning and sometimes the choice of aircraft. Live animals and travel documents are the two things you never assume, and both are checked against the destination's rules rather than the family's expectations.

Your checklist, before every departure. Is the FBO named in writing and is that address in the driver's hands. Are the passport details copied from the document rather than from a previous trip. Does the crew know every allergy, and does the catering order say so too. What time must the aircraft be airborne for the crew to remain legal. Is parking confirmed at both ends. And is the tail number absent from every message that did not strictly need it.

Masterclass III · Fine Dining & Wine

Food is where a household is judged fastest, because everyone at the table has an opinion and nobody has to explain it. You are not expected to cook, nor to have a sommelier's palate. You are expected to know the vocabulary, to protect people from what could harm them, and to make a restaurant, a chef and a cellar behave as though the evening were easy.

The two services, and when each belongs. Plated service composes the dish in the kitchen and sets it before the guest, giving the chef full control, and it is now the norm almost everywhere including at the highest level. Silver service brings the food on a platter and transfers it to the guest's plate at the table, from the left, with a spoon and fork held in one hand. It is formal and slower. Family service puts the platters on the table; butler service offers the platter for the guest to serve themselves. Know which the house uses before your first dinner; mixing them within a meal reads as confusion rather than variety.

The brigade. The kitchen is organised in stations, and the names are worth knowing because you will use them on the telephone. The chef de cuisine runs the kitchen, the sous chef deputises, and the chefs de partie hold the stations: saucier for sauces,

poissonnier for fish, entremetier for vegetables and soups, garde manger for cold work, patissier for pastry. In a private house the brigade collapses into one or two people running every station, the ordering and a budget at once. Understanding that compression separates a reasonable request from an impossible one.

The maitre d'hotel, and how tables really open. The maitre d'hotel controls the room: which table, what time, how long you keep it, and what is possible tonight that was not possible this morning. At the best houses the booking system is not the real door. The real door is a person who knows your name, and that relationship is built by being reliable rather than important. Book early, arrive on time, honour the covers you booked, cancel the moment you know, tip appropriately for the market, and never invoke the principal's name as leverage. Then, when you telephone in genuine need, the answer is often yes. Reliability is the currency, and it is earned over a year rather than an evening.

Dietary and allergy protocol, which is safety and not preference. Keep two separate lists. Preferences are dislikes. Allergies and intolerances are medical, and coeliac disease or a true allergy is not a dietary choice. Communicate allergies in writing at booking, again in the confirmation, and verbally to whoever serves the table, because the chain from reservation to plate passes through several hands. Ask about cross contamination for severe allergies, since a kitchen may omit an ingredient yet still handle it nearby. Know whether anyone carries an adrenaline auto injector and who is trained to use it. Never let an allergy be softened into a request for something on the side.

Wine service, the parts that are technique. Decanting does two things: it separates the wine from its sediment and it introduces air. Older reds are decanted carefully and served soon, since a fragile wine tires in air. Younger structured reds benefit from time open. Temperature does more for a wine than glassware. Sparkling wines and light whites are served well chilled, fuller whites a little warmer, lighter reds cool from the cellar, and full bodied reds at room temperature by the standard of an unheated room rather than a modern drawing room, which is why most red is served too warm. Glassware follows shape, not price: a larger bowl for aromatic reds, narrower for whites, a fine tall glass for sparkling. Pour to the widest part of the bowl, no further.

Classifications, in outline. These are legal and historical frameworks rather than quality guarantees, but they are the shorthand of the table. In Bordeaux, the 1855 classification of the Medoc ranks estates from first to fifth growth and has changed only once, while Saint Emilion runs its own, revised periodically. In Burgundy the ranking attaches to the land, rising from regional to village, premier cru and grand cru, and in Champagne the cru rating attaches to the village. Italy uses DOC and DOCG; Spain uses DO and DOCa with ageing terms such as crianza, reserva and gran reserva. Knowing that Burgundy classifies vineyards while Bordeaux classifies estates is worth more than memorising any list.

Corkage and the bottle you bring. Bringing your own wine is normal in some markets and unheard of in others, and even where allowed it is a favour rather than a right. Where a house permits it, expect a fee per bottle, a limit on the number, and a refusal for anything already on the list. Ask in advance rather than at the door, deliver the bottles earlier in the day so they rest and reach temperature, and offer the sommelier a taste. Where the fee is waived, tip as though it had not been.

Tasting menus. A tasting menu is a fixed sequence timed by the kitchen, and it changes the shape of an evening. It usually requires the whole table, is often confirmed at booking, and runs long, so a party with a fixed departure is told the realistic duration before it sits. Dietary adaptations are agreed days ahead rather than announced on arrival, because the kitchen has already bought for the sequence. The wine pairing is optional and generous, so ask about half pours, and arrange something equally considered for anyone not drinking.

Briefing a private chef. Give a chef information rather than instructions. The occasion, the numbers, the time, the setting. Who has an allergy and who simply dislikes. What the family has eaten in the last three days, because repetition is the most common quiet complaint. Who is arriving from a long flight and would rather eat lightly. The budget envelope for the week and who approves anything beyond it. Then leave the menu to the chef. Protect the kitchen from last minute guest numbers, and tell a chef about a cancellation the moment you know, because the food is already bought.

The cellar. A cellar is an asset and an inventory, and it deserves the discipline of both. Store bottles on their side, in the dark, at a steady cool temperature with moderate humidity, away from vibration. Stability matters more than any single number. Keep a record with wine, vintage, quantity, bin location, source, date and drinking window, and track what leaves and who authorised it, because unrecorded consumption is the most common cellar loss and it falls on whoever stands nearest the door. Value the cellar for insurance on a defined cadence and keep the storage history, since for fine wine that history carries much of the value.

How it fails. It fails when an allergy travels by memory. It fails when a table booked for eight receives six without a call. It fails when a principal's name is used to force a reservation, or when a great bottle is served too warm from a heated room, or when a chef learns at five that four more are coming. And it fails when a cellar has no record, so nobody can prove what was there.

Case I. The allergy at the table. As the first course is served, a guest mentions in passing that they cannot eat shellfish. The second course is built on a shellfish stock, and the kitchen is one chef and one commis.

The debrief. Do not improvise at the table and do not ask the guest how serious it is in front of the others. Go to the kitchen quietly and give the chef the fact and the time

available. Ask two questions: can that guest's course be replaced from stock on hand, and is there a cross contamination risk in the pans already in use. Then tell the guest privately that their second course will differ slightly, without drama and without apology, since apology invites the whole table in. Afterwards fix the system rather than the evening: dietary information is collected in writing when guests are invited. Never let a kitchen learn about an allergy from a plate coming back.

Case II. The impossible reservation. The principal wants a table on Saturday at a restaurant committed for months, and asks you to make it happen.

The debrief. Telephone rather than email, at a quiet hour of their day, and be honest: you know the date is impossible, you would like to be kept in mind for a cancellation, and you will gladly take an early or late seating. Flexibility is the only thing you have to offer. In parallel, secure a genuinely excellent alternative and present both, framing the alternative as a choice rather than a defeat. Never claim a table is held for you, and never send a driver to wait on a walk in. Access is a relationship kept in good standing over years, and the fastest way to lose it is to spend it once, loudly, on a Saturday.

Your checklist, before any meal that matters. Is every allergy in writing, in the booking, and known to whoever serves. Does the chef have the numbers, the timing and what the family ate this week. Are the wines out early enough to reach temperature. Does the restaurant know your real arrival time. Is there a plan for the guest who is not drinking. And is everything taken from the cellar recorded, with a name against it.

Masterclass IV · Art & Collections

A great house does not merely own objects. It holds a collection, and a collection is a legal, financial and physical responsibility that outlives everyone in the room. You will not be asked to have taste. You will be asked to make sure nothing is lost, damaged, undervalued or quietly rendered unsaleable.

Provenance, the word that governs everything. Provenance is the documented chain of ownership of a work, from the artist's studio to the wall you are looking at. It authenticates, it protects value, and it is the first thing a saleroom, an insurer or a buyer will ask for. Two rules. Never let a valuable object move without a record. And treat a gap in the chain between 1933 and 1945 as a serious matter to be verified rather than assumed, because works displaced in that period are still being restituted today. Where a doubt exists, a search of the Art Loss Register is routine, not an insult.

The attribution ladder, and why one word changes the value tenfold. Catalogues are precise, and the precision is the information. *By* the artist means fully autograph. *Attributed to* means probably, in the cataloguer's opinion. *Studio of* means made in the artist's studio, under supervision. *Circle of* means by an unidentified hand close to the

artist, in the period. *Follower of* means in the style, possibly later. *Manner of* means in the style, and later. *After* means a copy. If a principal says "we have a Sargent" and the invoice says "manner of", you now know two different things, and only one of them is a fact.

The object file, which is your actual work. For every piece worth recording: a unique reference, photographs of front, back and any labels, dimensions given both sight and framed, medium and support, edition number and cast number where relevant, the acquisition source, date and invoice, the provenance file, the most recent valuation and its date, the location history, and the name of the conservator who has treated it. The back of a picture, with its labels and stamps, is often worth more than the front for tracing history. Photograph it every time it moves.

The environment, which is silent and unforgiving. Stability matters more than any single number. Aim for a relative humidity around fifty per cent and hold it steady; it is the swing, not the level, that opens joints, lifts paint and buckles panels. Light is cumulative and the damage is permanent: works on paper, watercolours, photographs and textiles should sit near fifty lux, oil and tempera tolerate more. Never hang above a working fireplace, over a radiator, on a damp exterior wall, or in the path the sun will take in a season you have not yet lived through in that house. Walk the rooms at different hours before you decide.

Handling and movement. Two people to every work, always, even a light one. Carry a framed picture by the sides, upright, never by the top rail of the frame, and never with a hand on the surface. Watches, rings and belt buckles come off first. Nitrile gloves for gilded frames, photographs and metal; clean bare hands are sometimes preferable to cotton on a slippery gilt frame, and any professional will tell you which. For transit, soft wrap for a short local move, a purpose built crate for anything else, with a fine art carrier using climate control and air ride suspension, not a general removals firm. A condition report is written and photographed before departure and again on arrival, by both sides. Across borders, temporary movement usually travels under an ATA carnet, and long term storage often sits in a freeport, which is a customs area, not a cupboard.

Insurance and valuation. A household policy is not a fine art policy. What you want is nail to nail cover, which follows the work off the wall, through transit, into an exhibition and back. Understand whether the schedule is written at agreed value or at market value, because the difference appears only on the day of a claim. Revalue on a defined cadence, every three to five years and after any significant market move, using an accredited appraiser. The most common quiet failure in a private collection is not theft. It is a collection insured at the values of a decade ago.

The saleroom, in the words used. The estimate is a range, published. The reserve is the confidential minimum the seller will accept, and it sits at or below the low estimate. The hammer price is what the bidding reaches. The buyer's premium is added on top, and at the major houses it is a substantial percentage of the hammer on the first

tranche, tapering above it, so the invoice always exceeds the hammer. When selling, the seller pays a commission and often illustration, insurance and transport costs. A lot that fails to reach its reserve is bought in, and a work that has publicly failed is said to be burned, which is why quiet private treaty sales exist. In the United Kingdom and much of Europe, a resale right royalty may be payable to a living artist or the artist's estate on resale above a threshold.

Loans to institutions. A loan is a contract. It specifies insurance or a government indemnity, the environmental conditions required, whether a courier travels with the work, and who signs the condition report at each end. A loan can enhance provenance and exhibition history, which is a real asset. It can also return a work with a bloom, a knock or a new label, which is why the condition report at the door is not a formality.

How it fails. It fails when a work is moved by whoever was available. It fails when a well meaning person cleans a surface with a household product, and the loss is permanent and visible for the rest of the object's life. It fails when a piece is lent on a handshake. It fails when a valuation is a decade old. And it fails when nobody can find the invoice, because without the paper the object is worth what a buyer is willing to gamble.

Case I. The wall that was free. The principal wants the large canvas from the study moved to the new drawing room, above the fireplace, in time for a dinner on Friday. The house has a handyman on site and a van.

The debrief. Nothing moves on Friday. Above a working fireplace is one of the few placements a conservator will refuse outright, because of heat and soot. You do not argue taste, you offer an alternative: propose two walls that hold the picture at the same visual importance, away from heat, radiators and the afternoon sun, and have a fine art installer, not the handyman, fix it with security fittings. Photograph the back before it leaves the study, write the condition report, and update the location field in the inventory the same day. If the dinner cannot wait, the honest answer is that the room is beautiful without it this week.

Case II. The gift. A guest sends a small bronze as a thank you. It arrives unannounced, with a card and no paperwork.

The debrief. An unrecorded object in a house is a future problem for someone. Open a file the day it arrives: photographs including the underside and any foundry mark, dimensions, the date and the circumstances of the gift, and the card itself, which is now provenance. Ask the family office whether it should be added to the schedule, because an uninsured object is also an unrecorded one. And say nothing about its value to anyone, including the person who gave it.

Your checklist, in a house with a collection. Is there a single inventory, and is it current. Is everything on the schedule, at a valuation less than five years old. Is there a named conservator and a named fine art carrier in the black book, before they are

needed. Does anyone but you know where the provenance files live. And has anybody walked the rooms with a light meter and a hygrometer, at more than one hour of the day.

Masterclass V · Security & Close Protection

Security is the one domain where your instinct to be helpful can do real harm. Most exposure in a private household is created not by attackers but by ordinary people being efficient: a schedule forwarded to save time, a photograph posted from a driveway, a delivery let through because the van looked right. Your work is not to be brave. It is to be quiet, disciplined and slightly slower than everyone else.

The detail, and where your authority ends. A close protection team, the detail, exists to keep a principal physically safe. It is led by a team leader, and on larger operations a head of security sits above it, covering residences, travel and risk generally. You are not part of that chain of command. In a genuine incident the detail gives instructions and everyone follows them, including you, including the family office, including the principal. Your standing comes from being the person who gives them accurate information early. Never negotiate with a detail in front of the principal, never overrule them on movement, and never let a family member use you to route around them.

The advance. The advance is a visit made before the principal arrives anywhere: a restaurant, a hotel, a school, a venue, a house. It establishes the route, the parking, the entrance actually to be used, the nearest hospital, the exits, the layout of the room, where the table sits relative to the door, who is on duty, and what has changed since last time. In many households the concierge or house manager does the practical half of this and the detail does the security half. Do it in person where you can. A photograph of a doorway tells you nothing about the twenty metres of pavement in front of it.

Threat assessment, in outline. Professionals think in three terms: the threat, meaning who might wish harm and with what capability, the vulnerability, meaning what is open to them, and the consequence. Most private household risk is unglamorous: burglary, opportunistic theft, fraud, stalking, harassment, intrusive photography, and disputes involving former staff or family members. Kidnap and extortion risk is real in specific geographies and is assessed by specialists rather than assumed. You are not the assessor. You are the sensor, and what you contribute is the pattern: the car that has been outside three mornings, the caller who knew the children's names, the contractor who asked which weeks the house is empty.

Movement planning, which is never done alone. Every significant journey has a primary route and an alternative, a departure time that is not the same every day, a named driver, a vehicle known in advance, and someone at each end expecting the

arrival. Predictability is the underlying vulnerability in almost every household, and it is created by routine rather than by secrecy. You do not build a movement plan by yourself. You draft the logistics, the detail approves the security elements, and the plan is agreed before anyone tells the principal what time to be ready. If there is no detail, you still do not decide alone: the family office or the head of security signs it off.

Residential security and zones. Think of a property in layers: the perimeter, the grounds, the building envelope, the interior, and the safe room or refuge if one exists. Each layer should delay and detect rather than merely deter. That means lighting, cameras covering approaches and entrances, an alarm with a monitored response and a tested duress code, controlled keys with a register, and doors and glazing appropriate to the risk. Test the system on a schedule and record it. Know who holds keys and codes, change them when anyone leaves, and know how the house behaves in a power cut. A safe room is worthless if half the household does not know it exists or cannot reach it.

Vetting, for staff and for vendors. Everyone who enters is a potential vector, and most incidents involve someone with legitimate access. Vetting means verified identity, right to work, employment history with references taken by voice rather than by letter, and criminal record checking where local law permits. For vendors, the questions are who exactly will attend, will it be the same people each time, are they supervised, and are they insured. Contractors sign confidentiality terms as a matter of course. Nobody works unaccompanied in a private area. And the moment anyone leaves, keys, codes, passes, devices and system access are recovered the same day rather than at some convenient point later.

Information discipline. The most valuable thing an outsider can obtain is not an object. It is a schedule. Guest lists, itineraries, flight details, tail numbers, school runs, hotel names, room numbers and the dates a house stands empty are restricted, and they travel on a strict need to know basis rather than a helpful one. Say the principal rather than the name where you can. Use codes for residences and vehicles if the house does. Send documents rather than paste details into messages, and never put a full itinerary in a group chat with vendors in it. When a caller asks a question you cannot answer, the correct response is to take a number and call back through a channel you already trust.

Social media, photography and travel. Photographs carry location data, and even stripped of it they carry reflections, house numbers, gates, views, uniforms and number plates. The rule in most houses is simple: no photographs of the principal, the family, the interiors or the vehicles, ever, and nothing posted about where you work at all, including after you leave. Nothing is posted in real time by anybody. For travel, check the destination's advisories, know the local emergency numbers and the nearest suitable hospital, brief locally hired drivers, and never send a hotel a full itinerary by open email.

What you never put in writing. Assume anything you write may be read by someone you did not intend. That means no speculation about a family member's health, finances, relationships or state of mind, no commentary on other staff, no jokes about security arrangements, and no security detail such as codes, alarm procedures, safe room locations or vulnerabilities anywhere except the controlled document that exists for them. This is not paranoia. Household messages surface in disputes, in litigation and in breaches, and the difference between a professional and a liability is often a single line typed quickly.

How it fails. It fails through routine, because the same car leaves at the same minute every day. It fails when a schedule is forwarded to be helpful. It fails when a delivery is admitted because the uniform looked right. It fails when a former employee's codes are still live a month later. It fails when a family member asks you to lose the detail for an hour and you agree. And it fails when someone posts a photograph of a beautiful hallway.

Case I. The car you did not book. The principal's adult child telephones from a city where the family has no presence and asks you to send a car to a private address at midnight, and asks you not to mention it to the detail or the family office.

The debrief. You do not keep this secret and you do not refuse in a way that guarantees they simply arrange it themselves, badly. Say plainly that you will help and that you cannot conceal a movement, because that is the arrangement everyone works under. Then make it safe: a vetted operator rather than a street vehicle, the driver's name and plate confirmed, a live location shared with one agreed person, and a call on arrival. Inform the head of security or the detail directly and only them, with the minimum necessary, not the whole family. If you had concealed it and something went wrong, you would have been the reason help arrived late. The general rule is that discretion means telling the right person, not telling nobody.

Case II. The journalist at the gate. A caller reaches the house line, gives a name and a publication, and asks you to confirm whether the family is in residence and whether a particular guest stayed last weekend.

The debrief. You confirm nothing, including the things that seem harmless, because confirming a negative also confirms a pattern. The wording is neutral and repeatable: you are not able to discuss the household, and you will pass the request on. Take the name, the publication and the number, end the call politely, and do not be drawn into correcting anything they claim to know already, since that is the technique. Then report it immediately, in writing, to the family office and the head of security, with the exact time, the exact wording and the number. One approach is an approach. Three in a week is a pattern, and the pattern only becomes visible if you wrote the first one down.

Your checklist, in any household. Do you know who leads security and how to reach them out of hours. Is there a written movement plan for regular journeys, and does it

vary. Who holds keys and codes, and when were they last changed. Is there an alarm test on a schedule and a duress code anyone has practised. Does every vendor with access have a name, a check and a confidentiality term. And is there anything in your phone right now that you would not want read aloud.

Masterclass VI • The Family Office

Behind almost every substantial family sits an office, and the office is where your contract, your payroll, your budget and your reference actually live. Many capable people fail in private service not because they served badly but because they never worked out who they answer to. The family is the reason for the job. The office is usually the employer. Those are two different relationships and they require two different registers.

Single, multi and embedded. A single family office serves one family and exists to manage its wealth, its assets, its philanthropy, its property and, often, its household staff. A multi family office serves several families and sells a shared professional infrastructure, which means shorter access, standard processes and staff who are not exclusively yours. Some families instead run a small private secretariat inside an operating business, which blurs the boundary between corporate and household and makes the reporting line harder to read. None is better. What matters to you is which one you are in, because it determines how decisions are made, how quickly, and how much explaining you will do.

Who signs and who decides. These are almost never the same person, and confusing them is the most common early error. The principal decides what the family wants. The office decides whether it is approved, funded, contracted and recorded. A request from a family member is not authorisation to spend. Your first week in any structure should establish, in writing if possible, who approves expenditure at each level, who signs contracts, who instructs payments, and what you may commit without asking. Until you know that, treat every commitment as provisional and say so plainly rather than promising a vendor something you cannot yet fund.

The chief of staff. Larger structures place a chief of staff or a principal's private secretary between the family and everyone else. That person manages the principal's time, priorities and access, and effectively decides what reaches them. Understand quickly whether your reporting line runs through the chief of staff or beside it. If it runs through, everything goes to them first and you resist the pull of a family member who prefers to ask you directly. If it runs beside, you still copy them, because a chief of staff who learns something from a third party will not make that mistake twice. This relationship, kept in good order, is the single greatest professional asset you will have inside a family office.

Budgets and thresholds. Well run households operate to an annual budget by category: staffing, maintenance, utilities, provisions, entertaining, travel, vehicles, garden, security, and a contingency. Within it sit approval thresholds, so that small amounts run on your own authority, middling amounts need one approval, and larger amounts need two or a formal sign off. Learn the thresholds on day one and never split an invoice to stay beneath one, because that is the single fastest way to end a career in this field. If a category is running ahead of budget, you raise it while it is a variance and not after it is an overspend. Nobody minds a number that moves. They mind finding out late.

Expense discipline and reconciliation. Assume every transaction you touch will be examined by someone who was not there. Receipts for everything, coded to the right category, with the reason and the beneficiary noted where it is not obvious. Household cards are used for household expenditure only, never for anything personal even briefly and even repaid, because the appearance is the problem rather than the amount. Petty cash is counted and signed. Reconcile on a fixed cadence rather than when asked. Where the family and a business share suppliers, keep the entities cleanly separate, since a private expense recorded against a company is somebody else's serious problem and it will find its way back to you.

Who holds your contract, and who holds your reference. Read your contract to find the legal employer. It may be the family personally, the family office, a service company, a property company or an agency. That entity is who pays you, who owes you notice, who owns your confidentiality obligation and, in practice, who signs your reference. Warmth from a family member is not a contractual position. The person who loves your work may not be the person authorised to confirm your dates and duties later, and in many structures references are issued centrally in a limited factual form. Know that before you leave rather than after, and keep your own dated record of duties and achievements.

Reporting cadence. Reporting is not an imposition, it is how you become trusted at a distance. Agree a rhythm and hold it without being chased: a short weekly note of what happened, what is coming and what needs a decision; a monthly view of budget against actual with variances explained; and an immediate report for anything involving money lost, damage, injury, a legal matter, media contact or a departure. Keep the weekly note factual and short. The skill is compression, not completeness. A family office reading three concise paragraphs from you each week will approve things faster than one that receives nothing and then a crisis.

Confidentiality inside the structure. Confidentiality is not only outward facing. Information moves on a need to know basis within the office as well, and financial, medical, legal and personal matters are compartmentalised for good reason. A colleague being senior does not entitle them to a detail you hold. The correct answer, delivered without drama, is that you are not able to discuss it and that they should

speak to whoever owns that area. Equally, do not become the person who collects what other people say. In a small structure the person who trades in information is identified quickly, and they are never promoted.

Escalating without going over a head. Escalation is a normal, healthy act, and the way it is done determines whether it costs you. Raise it first with the person closest to the problem and give them a genuine chance to solve it. If it stalls, tell them you are taking it up, and say so before you do it rather than after. Then present it upward as a decision to be made, not a complaint: here is the issue, here is what I have tried, here are two options, here is what I recommend and by when it must be decided. Reserve going straight to the top for safety, legality, and the wellbeing of a person. Everything else waits a day and goes through the proper door.

How it fails. It fails when a family member's wish is treated as an approval. It fails when a vendor is engaged and the office learns of it from the invoice. It fails when receipts accumulate in a drawer. It fails when someone becomes the family's confidant and forgets they are the office's employee. It fails when a threshold is quietly avoided. And it fails when a person who was excellent for four years leaves with no written record of what they actually did.

Case I. The vase and the approval that never came. A family member sees a piece at an auction on Friday and asks you to secure it. The amount sits well above your threshold, the office is closed until Monday, and the sale is Saturday.

The debrief. Do not bid. Do not lend the money personally and do not put it on a household card intending to sort it out later; both destroy the boundary that protects you. Work the problem instead. Establish the deadline exactly, then use the escalation route that exists for precisely this, which is the out of hours contact for the office or the chief of staff. If nobody can be reached, tell the family member plainly what you can and cannot do, and offer the alternatives: an absentee bid registered within an authorised limit if one can be confirmed in time, or the saleroom's after sale and private treaty routes if the lot goes unsold. Then write it down. The general rule is that urgency never converts a wish into an authorisation, and that the fix is a working out of hours route agreed in advance.

Case II. The question you should not answer. A senior person in the office asks you, casually, whether one of the principal's children is still living at a particular residence and who has been staying there.

The debrief. Seniority is not the test; need to know is. Answer the same way you would answer an outsider, courteously and without implication: you are not able to discuss the household's arrangements, and if it is needed for something in particular you are glad to help through the right route. Then ask yourself whether the request was legitimate, and if it concerns you, raise it with whoever owns household confidentiality. Do not tell the family. Do not tell colleagues. The general rule is that the answer to an improper

question is the same regardless of who asked, and delivering it pleasantly is what makes it survivable.

Your checklist, in any structure. Who is your legal employer, in writing. Who approves what, and at what amount. Who is the out of hours contact, and have you tested it before you needed it. What is the reporting rhythm you have committed to, and have you held it for a month. Is your expenditure reconciled to date, today. And if you left in three months, who would issue your reference, and does that person know what you actually do.

Masterclass VII · Health, Emergency & Medical Logistics

Health is the category where the calm competent person is worth more than everything else in the house combined. You are not a clinician and nothing here makes you one. Your work is logistical: to know who to call, to have the documents ready before they are wanted, to protect the most sensitive information you will ever hold, and to do the right small things in the first ninety seconds while somebody more qualified is on the way.

Private and concierge medicine. Many families hold a retainer with a private practice or concierge physician, which typically buys direct access to a named doctor, appointments at short notice, longer consultations, home or hotel visits and coordination of referrals. Some extend internationally through a network. Understand what your family's arrangement actually covers, its geographic limits, whether it includes dependants and staff, and how it is reached out of hours, because a retainer nobody can reach at two in the morning is not a service. A retainer is not insurance. Know separately what the family's health cover includes, in which countries, and to what limits.

The medical file, and who may hold it. Health information is a special category of personal data in most privacy regimes and carries heavier obligations than anything else you handle. Whether you may hold a family's medical details at all depends on the jurisdiction, the employer's arrangements and the individual's consent, and that is answered by the family office or its advisers rather than by you. Where you are authorised, hold the minimum: blood group, allergies, current medications and doses, chronic conditions, significant past surgery, the treating physician, and insurance details. Store it encrypted, restrict who can open it, keep it out of shared drives and group chats, and review it on a cadence, because an out of date file misleads a clinician at exactly the wrong moment.

Allergy and anaphylaxis. Anaphylaxis is a severe, rapid, life threatening allergic reaction, and a medical emergency. If anyone in the household or a regular guest

carries an adrenaline auto injector, know where it lives in each residence and vehicle, keep that location fixed and never moved for tidiness, and check expiry dates on a schedule. Everyone who might be present, including drivers and seasonal staff, should be trained by a qualified provider in recognising a reaction and using the device, with refreshers. When travelling, the device goes in the cabin with the prescription. In an emergency you call for help and follow the individual's prescribed plan; nothing written here replaces that plan or a clinician's instruction.

Medication across borders. This is where households get into genuine trouble without meaning to. A medicine that is ordinary at home can be a controlled substance elsewhere, and several common categories, including strong painkillers, stimulants prescribed for attention disorders, some sedatives and some cold remedies, are restricted or prohibited in certain countries. The consequences fall on the traveller rather than the prescriber. Before any trip, check the destination's rules through its embassy or health authority, carry medicines in original labelled packaging with a copy of the prescription and, where required, a doctor's letter naming the traveller, condition, medicine and dose, keep it all in hand luggage, and carry only a reasonable quantity. Where a permit is required, apply well ahead, because these are not issued at a counter.

Travel health. Vaccination requirements are country specific and change, and some vaccines need weeks to take effect or a course over months, so travel health advice belongs at the start of planning rather than the week before. Some countries require proof of vaccination for entry. Beyond that, the practical concerns are water, food risk, insect borne disease and altitude, and the family's physician is the source for all of it. Build a travel health note into every itinerary: local emergency number, chosen hospital, the insurer's assistance line and the policy number.

Choosing a hospital before you need one. This is the most valuable line on the page. For every destination the family visits regularly and every trip of consequence, identify in advance the nearest hospital with a genuine emergency department and, separately, the best facility for serious care, which is often not the nearest. Note whether it is public or private, whether it takes the family's insurance or requires payment on admission, what languages are spoken, its address written in the local language for a driver, and the realistic journey time at the worst hour. Record it in the trip file. Choosing a hospital in the back of a car at night, in a language nobody in the vehicle reads, is how avoidable outcomes happen.

Evacuation and repatriation. Medical evacuation moves a patient to appropriate care, sometimes by air ambulance. Repatriation brings them home once stable. Both are expensive, complex, and frequently excluded or capped by ordinary travel policies, so families who travel to remote places usually hold a specialist membership or dedicated cover. Know which, its assistance number, its exclusions, whether pre authorisation is required before treatment, and whether it follows the family only or

also the staff travelling with them. Ask that last question on your own behalf before you are asked to accompany anyone anywhere. The decision to evacuate is clinical, taken by the treating physician with the assistance provider, and never by the household.

The emergency card every house should have. One page, current, held where anyone can find it and known to every member of staff. It carries the residence address as an emergency service needs it, with access instructions, gate codes and the nearest cross street; the local emergency number; the family's physician; the chosen hospital; the insurer and policy number; the assistance line; the next of kin and decision maker for each household member; and where the first aid kit and any auto injector are kept. Keep an equivalent for each trip, and print it. In a real incident networks fail, phones lock, and the person who needs the information is not the person who compiled it.

The first ninety seconds. Your role is small, specific and enormously useful. Call emergency services first rather than a relative, because minutes decide outcomes. Give the address clearly and stay on the line, because the dispatcher will direct you and those instructions take precedence over anything else. Send someone to open the gate and meet the ambulance, since gated and rural properties are where crews lose time. Clear a corridor. Gather the medication list. Keep other people calm and out of the room. Note the time symptoms began, which clinicians will ask. Then hand over completely and step back.

How it fails. It fails when the auto injector is moved to a tidier drawer, or when a controlled medicine crosses a border in an unlabelled box, or when a trip file lists a hotel and no hospital. It fails when three people know the gate code and none is at home, and when a medical detail is repeated to someone who had no need of it. And it fails when a household depends on one person's memory and that person is on leave.

Case I. The reaction at lunch. A guest at a family lunch reacts badly to something and becomes distressed and breathless. The household knows they carry an auto injector, but nobody is certain where the bag is.

The debrief. Call emergency services immediately and follow the dispatcher's instructions. You do not wait to see whether it improves, and you do not telephone the family doctor first. One person stays with the guest, a second finds the bag, a third opens the gate and waits at the road to guide the crew in. Tell the dispatcher what was eaten and when symptoms began. Never give anyone else's medication. Afterwards, record what happened and fix the underlying failure, which was that guest dietary and medical information was never collected at invitation and nobody had asked where the device was. In a medical event you make one call, you make it first, and everything after it is about getting trained people to the patient faster.

Case II. The pills in the wash bag. The day before a trip you are asked to pack a family member's medication. Among it is a prescription stimulant, loose in an unlabelled container, and the destination is strict.

The debrief. You neither pack it nor quietly leave it behind, because both are decisions that are not yours. Raise it with the right person, meaning the family member or their physician and the family office, not the wider household. Check the destination's rules through its embassy or health authority, and ask the prescriber for a labelled dispensed supply with a covering letter naming the traveller, condition, medicine and daily dose, plus a permit where that country requires one. If time does not allow it, the honest answer is that the medicine cannot travel on this trip and the physician should advise on the alternative. Medication is a legal question before it is a packing question, and health matters are discussed with the smallest possible number of people.

Your checklist, in any household. Is there a current emergency card in every residence, and does everyone know where. Do you know the chosen hospital for each place the family regularly goes. Have you confirmed what the retainer covers, what the insurance covers, and what neither does. Are auto injectors present, in date and in a fixed place, and has anyone been trained recently. Are medications checked against destination rules before every international trip. And are you holding any health information you were never authorised to hold.

Masterclass VIII · Privacy, Data & Digital Hygiene

The modern attack on a wealthy family almost never comes through a window. It comes through an inbox, usually addressed to the household rather than the family, because criminals correctly assume staff are helpful, busy and less protected than a bank. Being good at this is not technical. It is a set of habits held consistently, on the days when they are inconvenient.

The footprint you did not choose. A family's digital footprint is assembled by other people: company filings, property registers, donations, school communities, planning applications, vessel and aircraft registries, press coverage, and the accounts of friends, guests and staff. You will not erase it. What you can reduce is what is fresh. Old information is history; current information, a location, a schedule, a vehicle, a school gate, is operational. Review periodically what appears publicly about the residences and the family, and route anything needing formal removal to the family office and its advisers rather than attempting it yourself.

Why household staff are the target. Attackers study a target's suppliers, staff names and routines, then approach whoever is most likely to be useful at speed. The three levers are authority, urgency and plausibility: a message appearing to come from the principal, a deadline that removes time to think, and enough true detail to feel real. That detail is not evidence of legitimacy, it is evidence of research. The professional reflex is the opposite of the helpful one: slow down precisely when a message tells you to hurry.

Payment instructions, and the rule that never bends. Invoice fraud is among the most common serious losses in private households, and it works simply: an attacker intercepts or imitates a supplier's correspondence and sends new bank details for a genuine invoice. Every change of payment details is verified by voice, on a number from your own records, never a number in the message and never by replying to the email. Verify the first payment to any new supplier the same way. Where amounts are significant, require two approvers. A message from a principal asking you to move money urgently and confidentially is the classic pattern, and the response is to telephone them on their known number and tell the family office regardless.

Credentials. Use a reputable password manager and long unique passwords, because the real danger is reuse: one breached service exposes every account sharing that password. Turn on multi factor authentication on email first, then banking, then everything else, preferring an authenticator application or a physical key to codes sent by text, which can be intercepted. Never share a login by message, and never run a household account that several people open with one password, because it destroys accountability. When anyone leaves, revoke access the same day across every system, including the shared calendars and delivery accounts everyone forgets.

Devices. Keep work and personal separate as far as the household allows. Encrypt every device, use a strong lock with a short timeout, and keep systems updated, since most successful intrusions exploit something already patched. Turn off lock screen message previews, because a locked phone on a table still shows an arriving message to anyone standing near it. Avoid public wireless for anything that matters, never plug in an unknown drive or charge from an unknown port, and lock your screen every time you stand up in a house where cleaners, contractors and guests move freely.

The home network and the smart house. A residence now holds dozens of connected devices and every one is a door. Change every default password, particularly on cameras, doorbells, routers and video recorders, since default credentials are published and scanned for automatically. Put the family on one network, guests on a separate guest network, and connected devices on a third, so a compromised device cannot reach a family laptop. Update firmware. Know who installed the system, who retains remote access, and remove any integrator's standing access no longer needed. Voice assistants listen for a wake word and record afterwards, so they belong in no study, bedroom or room where confidential conversations happen.

Cameras, and where they must never be. Cameras protect a perimeter. Inside a residence they create risk and liability in equal measure, and in most jurisdictions there are places they may not lawfully be: bathrooms, changing areas, bedrooms and staff private accommodation. Filming staff quarters is unlawful in many countries and indefensible everywhere. Where cameras exist, people must be informed, the legal basis and retention period are set by the family office rather than by you, access is restricted and logged, and audio is treated more strictly than video almost everywhere.

A request to place a camera somewhere private goes to the family office and its legal advisers, not to an installer.

Photographs and metadata. Photographs carry embedded data including time, device and often exact location, and it travels with the file when the image is emailed or messaged. Before any image of a property leaves your hands, for an insurer, a contractor or a valuer, strip the metadata and read the frame: house numbers, gate mechanisms, alarm panels, safe doors, keys on a hook, a screen, a document, a view that identifies the address. The safest household rule is the simplest: photograph nothing of the family, the interiors or the vehicles, and post nothing about where you work, ever, including after you leave.

The group chat. Household group chats are efficient and they are the most common leak in private service. What belongs there: shift changes, tradespeople's arrival times, unremarkable logistics. What never belongs there: itineraries, flight and tail numbers, room numbers, guest names, alarm codes, health information, photographs of the family or interiors, financial details, and any opinion about a family member or colleague. Assume every message is read one day by a lawyer, a journalist or the person it concerns. Keep household communication on a platform the office has approved.

How it fails. It fails when a bank detail is changed on the strength of an email, or when a doorbell camera keeps the password it was sold with, or when a departed gardener's login is still live at Christmas. It fails when a phone on a hall table shows a preview to a contractor, or when a photograph for the insurer contains the alarm panel. And it fails whenever somebody was helpful very quickly.

Case I. The message from the principal. At six on a Friday a message arrives, apparently from the principal, from a number you do not recognise. They are in a meeting, cannot take calls, and need a deposit sent urgently to a new supplier. The tone is right and the message mentions a detail only an insider would know.

The debrief. Every element of that message is a technique: new number, unavailable for a call, urgency, confidentiality, and a true detail taken from research or a previous breach. Do not reply, because replying confirms the number is live and hands the sender your writing style. Telephone the principal on the number you already hold, and if they do not answer, telephone the family office or the chief of staff. Send nothing until you have spoken to a person on a number from your own records. If it proves genuine, nobody sensible will criticise the check. Report it either way, because your household is unlikely to be the only one receiving it.

Case II. The tablet in the kitchen. A new smart home system is installed. The integrator leaves a tablet in the kitchen, permanently logged in, with access to the cameras, door locks, alarm and calendar, and gives the household one password that everyone uses.

The debrief. Convenience has removed every trace of accountability, and anyone standing in the kitchen now controls the house. Raise it with the family office as a risk rather than a complaint, and bring the fix: individual accounts so actions are attributable, multi factor authentication on the administrator account, a short lock on the tablet, camera access limited to named people, the integrator's remote access removed or made time limited and logged, and default passwords changed everywhere. Ask who owns the system contractually and who is accountable for its security, because in many houses the answer is nobody. Shared credentials are the same thing as no credentials, and raising it in writing protects the household and also protects you.

The first hour after a suspected breach. Speed matters more than certainty, so act on suspicion. Report at once to the family office and whoever holds security, and do not investigate quietly alone. Delete nothing, since the message, the header and the log are the evidence. Disconnect an affected device from the network but leave it powered on unless told otherwise. If money has moved, telephone the bank immediately and ask for a recall, because the first hours are the only hours in which funds are commonly recoverable. Change passwords from a different, clean device. Write a timeline while it is fresh. Then let the specialists work. The instinct to fix it before anyone notices is what turns an incident into a disaster.

Your checklist, in any household. Is every change of payment detail verified by voice, on a number from your own records. Does every household email account carry multi factor authentication. Are there shared logins anywhere, and who else still has access who has left. Were the default passwords changed on the cameras, the router and the doorbell. Is there a camera anywhere it should not be. And is there anything in the household group chat this week that you would not want read aloud in a courtroom.

Masterclass IX · Your Status, Pay & Mobility

This is the masterclass nobody teaches, and the one that decides whether a career in private service is sustainable or merely intense. The work is personal, the households are informal, and the money often arrives through arrangements nobody wrote down properly. Understanding your own position is not disloyalty. It is what lets you stay ten years instead of two. Nothing here is legal or tax advice, rules differ sharply between countries, and the answers belong to a qualified adviser in the relevant jurisdiction.

Employed or self employed, and why it decides everything. An employee works under direction, on set hours, integrated into the household, with equipment provided and no financial risk. A self employed contractor runs a business, serves several clients and carries the risk. Most authorities look at substance rather than label, so a household calling you self employed while directing your hours and forbidding other clients is probably wrong in law. Status carries notice, protection from unfair dismissal, paid holiday, sick pay and pension rights in most jurisdictions.

Who your legal employer actually is. Establish this in writing before you start. It may be a family member, a family office, a service company or an agency. That entity owes you notice and money and must be named if anything goes wrong, and it is rarely the person you serve daily. Ask under which law it employs you. If nobody can answer, that is information about how the household is run.

What must be in the contract. Insist on a written contract before you start. It should name the parties, the title and duties at a realistic scope, the start date, the places of work, salary with currency and payment date, hours, holiday, sick pay, notice on both sides, probation, accommodation, travel, confidentiality and the grievance route. Watch three clauses: duties so broad they mean anything, unlimited travel, and accommodation tied so tightly that losing the job means losing your home the same day. If a household resists a written contract, that is the most useful thing you will learn about them.

Notice, on both sides. Notice in senior private service commonly runs from one to three months, above statutory minimums a contract cannot undercut, though this varies by market. Check whether the household may pay in lieu and what happens to accommodation during notice. Probation usually carries less. Give the notice you agreed even when leaving is hard, because this industry is small and departures are discussed for years.

Live in accommodation. A live in role is a privilege and a complication. Establish whether the accommodation is provided for the better performance of the job, which in some jurisdictions affects how it is taxed and whether it counts as pay. Establish what happens when the employment ends, and negotiate a reasonable period to leave rather than the same afternoon. Get the practical points in writing: whether the space is genuinely private, whether visitors are permitted, and that nobody enters without notice. No camera or listening device belongs in staff accommodation, and in many countries it is unlawful there. Keep a home elsewhere if you can, because a role that is also your address concentrates too much in one relationship.

Hours and time off when you live where you work. The hardest thing about living in is that the job never visibly ends. Working time rules vary, and some countries exclude or partly exclude domestic work, so do not assume a protection you may not have. Define the week in the contract instead: which days are off and whether they are consecutive, what on call means and whether it is paid, how overtime is recognised, and what happens when the family travels and your rest days disappear. Then take the days you are given, in full, away from the house. Households rarely exploit people deliberately. They expand into whatever space is available.

Payroll and contributions. Insist on payslips showing gross, deductions and net, and check that tax and social contributions are actually paid rather than mentioned. Those contributions generate a state pension, unemployment cover and healthcare entitlement in many countries, and years paid in cash will not exist when you need

them. Be wary of any arrangement where part of the salary is unrecorded cash, because the exposure sits with you as well as the household, and because it reduces what you can prove when you apply for a visa, a tenancy or a mortgage. Keep your own copies of every payslip and contract, permanently.

Tax residency when you follow a family. Residency rules differ by country and commonly turn on days present, on where your permanent home and centre of vital interests sit, and on tie breaker tests in double taxation treaties. Keep your own record of travel, stamps and boarding passes. It is entirely possible to become tax resident somewhere without intending it, and to owe filings in two countries in one year. Social security follows its own rules, separately from income tax. Take advice in the year you start moving rather than the year a letter arrives, and ask whether the family office will fund it, because a well run office usually will.

Visas and the right to work. The right to work is granted by a country rather than by an employer's enthusiasm, and a household that wants you cannot arrange it in a week. This constraint quietly decides which roles are open to you. Some countries operate routes for domestic workers accompanying an employer, usually tied to that employer and time limited. Others have no practical route for private household roles, which is why certain markets recruit almost entirely from people who already hold status. A tourist visa permits work nowhere, and accepting a role on one risks your immigration record, not the household's. Know the difference between a visa tied to one employer and one that lets you move, because the first shapes your leverage in every conversation.

References, in this world. References here are personal, spoken and cautious. Many principals will not write anything at all, for privacy rather than dissatisfaction, and some offices issue only a factual confirmation of dates and title. So build the evidence as you go: dated records of responsibilities, budgets managed, projects delivered and staff supervised, none of them confidential. Ask, while you are in the role and on good terms, who would speak to a future employer, and keep that relationship warm afterwards. And never trade on a former principal's name in public or in a profile, because the discretion you show about your last house is the only evidence anyone has of the discretion you will show about the next.

How it fails. It fails when three years pass on a verbal agreement and no record exists, or when part of the pay was cash and the mortgage application wants payslips. It fails when a role ends and the home ends the same afternoon, when nobody counted days spent in a country, or when someone on an employer tied visa stays in an unhappy house because leaving means leaving the country. And it fails when a person departs in anger and burns the only reference they had.

Case I. The offer with no paperwork. You are offered an excellent role. The family office says the contract will follow, that everyone starts this way, and that the first

month will be paid against an invoice while payroll is arranged. They need you on Monday.

The debrief. You neither refuse nor simply accept. Reply warmly and in writing, setting out your understanding of the essentials, title, duties, salary, start date, hours, holiday and notice, and ask them to confirm it while the contract is drafted. That email is itself evidence if anything is later disputed. On the invoicing, ask whether the role is employed or self employed, because if it is employed then invoicing may misstate your status and the exposure lands on you. A well run office is never offended by a request to write things down, and one that is offended has told you something worth knowing.

Case II. The move you did not plan. The family announce that the household is relocating and that you will travel with them for most of the coming year, in long stretches across two other countries. Nobody has mentioned your contract, your visa or your tax position.

The debrief. Say yes to the principle and slow down the detail. Ask the office four questions in writing: which entity will employ you and under which law, what immigration status you will hold in each country and who is arranging it, how tax and social security will be handled and whether the office will fund advice, and how rest days work while travelling. None of it should sound like resistance; frame it as making sure you can travel with them lawfully and without an unpleasant surprise on either side. Start counting your days from the first flight. Mobility is the most valuable thing you have in this profession and the easiest to damage, and you protect it by asking early, in writing, in a friendly voice.

Your checklist, in any role. Do you have a written contract naming the legal employer. Are you employed or self employed, and does the reality match the label. Are payslips issued and contributions actually paid. If you live in, what happens to the accommodation when the role ends. How many days have you spent in each country this year. Is your right to work tied to this employer. And if you left tomorrow, who would speak for you, and have you asked them.